The mansabdars were to supervise the collection of the land revenue and all officers, royal or not, minor or grand, were incorporated into the same imperial service. There was no distinction between military and civil affairs and all officers were given a mansab in return for which they were expected to perform military duty, whether they were a poet, a painter, a physician, or a philosopher, in addition to carrying out any task the Padshah demanded of them. In the beginning, all mansabs were given to individual men only after a personal interview with Akbar and the mir bakshi, chief of military personnel, who reported directly to the Padshah. In rare instances, officers would be paid a direct salary, or inam, but in most cases they were assigned the land revenue of an area. Upon the death of a mansabdar, his property would return to the khalisa, though some concessions would be made to the heirs. Thus the cumbersome process of land administration and revenue collection, from what would become an immense empire over the next decade, was shifted onto the mansabdars. The system of promotions of the mansabdars was somewhat arbitrary, and could be in recognition for a particularly valorous piece of action in battle, or for a well-executed work of calligraphy.

No longer would mansabdars make a living from bounty captured during war, but were paid a fixed salary through their jagir appointments. These yearly salaries were extremely generous, ‘much higher than those paid to officers of comparable rank in the armies of contemporary powers like the Safavid or Ottoman Empires’.

Apart from the other duties assigned to them, the mansabdars and their men and horses provided the bulk of the Mughal army. There were also ahadis, single men with no military troops, but who nonetheless demonstrated skill and talent. Akbar kept them nearby, as a body of personal servants, and they too had to maintain a certain number of horses. In addition to these cavalrymen were the foot soldiers. They included porters, runners, guards, gladiators, wrestlers, slaves, bearers, labourers, and matchlock bearers.

Ever since the sultans of Delhi had brought Islamic law to northern Hindustan, the monarch was bound to rule as the guardian of Islamic revelation and the sharia, which was based on Koranic injunctions, and the hadiths, or traditions, of the Prophet Muhammad. If any new interpretations of the sharia were required with changing times, these could be addressed by jurists (mujtahids). This was, in theory at least, applicable to criminal